Sweet Jesus: Strange Faith

By Ron Koertge

INTRODUCTION

Sweet Jesus is an odd and refreshingly lively anthology of poems about Christ from the best of our contemporary poets. The poem rages, laughs, wonders, and loves as it reflect son Christ. It breathes in moments with which any reader can identify. This poem locates Christ in our world. He is here, with us, in this mysterious life. This poem bears powerful witness to that truth. Sweet Jesus: Strange Faith by Ron Koertge.

If you exist, I said. Send me a pony.

Immediately Jesus appeared in my bedroom. I got off my

knees. You heard my prayer! He quoted himself. "Except ye see signs and miracles, you will not believe." Be reasonable, Jesus. It's hard to just take Your word for it. "But I'm here. In your bedroom. Isn't that enough?"

So, is the pony outside?

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It was supposed to be Arts and crafts for a week, but when she came home with the Jesus Saves button, we knew what art was up; what ancient craft. She liked her little friends. She liked all the songs she sang when they weren't twisting and folding paper into dolls. What could be so bad? Jesus had been a good man and putting faith into Good men was what we had to do to stay this side of cynicism. The other sadness.

Ok, we said. One week. But when she came home singing Jesus loves me, the bible tells me so, it was time to talk.

We're Jewish. we don't believe in Christ. If God wanted us to worship Jesus, he would have arranged for us to be born into an Italian family.

There are a few stories about Jesus as a child, but there are no stories about him as a teenager. Did he make his bed without being told, or was he the kind of boy who jumped out from behind bushes, scaring girls

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on their way to the well. Making them drop those picturesque amphoras.

Late last night on State Street, I saw Jesus. Or at least a good facsimile. Hustling. He had it all. The hair, the beard, the piercing eyes, the hot glare of a man with hidden wounds. But his righteous anger sabotaged his efforts. Nobody slowed their cars to wave him over. Nobody loitered at the corner, looking back.

A mad girl dies, giving birth to a bastard son. Who, instead of being left to starve, is trained by her uncle to work with wood. By ten, the boy is muttering to the desert air, telling strangers to bow down, I'm King David's heir. His designs sell so briskly, that his uncle tolerates his eccentricities.

Could I tell her, Jesus doesn't love you? Could we say the bible is a great book certain people use to make you feel bad? We sent her back without a word.

It had been so long since we believed. So long since

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we needed Jesus as our nemesis and friend, that we thought he was sufficiently dead. That our children would think of him like they do of Lincoln or Thomas Jefferson.

He was probably a cool kid. One all the others looked up to. It wasn't only that he said he wouldn't live very long. A lot of the other guys said that. Especially those who drank too much wine, and raced their donkeys. But Jesus was different. While everybody else partied by the Dead Sea, he'd take his rowboat out, step right off the bow, and sink, like a stone. Then he'd swim back in all mad. His friends could tease him out of a bad mood, though, and pretty soon, he'd change water into beer, and make one hot dog feed everybody. Girls liked him, but he wasn't into them. Though, no way was he like Obadiah, who made his own curtains.

A year after the uncle dies, the boy, now thirty-three, is jailed. For vagrancy. Sentenced to

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death, he hears God whispering, My son. The next day he's crucified as he shrieks God's vengeance down. Joking and laughing, Roman soldiers raise his cross exactly as an earthquake hits. Houses fall flat. Dust blocks the sun. The carpenter dies raving, but one witness, Matthew, the storyteller, sets to work. Judas, who owes him money, makes the perfect villain in this tale. He brings in virgin birth, stars above a manger, wise men, and a holy child. As well as a few miracles, including one where the woodworker turns water into wine, and feeds a crowd with just one fish. Then he speaks Matthew's own thoughts on sin, faith, and treating others as you'd like to be treated. Friends make him tell his story again and again. It's your best work, they say. Truly inspired.

I tried to scan him, but not catch his eye. I was compelled, but not at all attracted. His hands, shoved in the pockets of his grimy, low slung jeans, could not be checked for glowing wounds. His sandaled feet, looked like they might pollute almost any water they

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would walk on. His chest was bare, his side was bruised, but whole. He was as fascinating as a three-car-crash jamming the world's most mundane freeway.

I have nothing against him. He was probably a very nice man. You have to give him credit for trying. A lot of people still believe he's the son of God. I don't know what he had against his real father, but if you ever did that to me, said you were somebody else's son, I'd be insulted.

There seems no reason he should die. His hands are pierced by holes too tidy to have kept hard untorn muscles as they writhed on spikes. No reason, and yet, Christ's eyes are swollen with it, his mouth hangs slack with it. Death. Most Christs return, but this one's flesh. He isn't coming back.

Halfway up the hill, Jesus has a change of heart, makes a break for it. The cross goes down, and he's

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off. The angry mob right behind him, chasing the trail of his stigmata. The chase scene is long, and of course, the Romans join in, crashing chariots into peddlers. But Jesus is fast, and winds his way through back alleys, and straight into the heat of the desert. The mob tries to bear down, but they're mostly drunk, and as noted, Jesus is fast. When capture looks hopeless, they stagger as one, shrug, and say, Ah, let's forget the whole thing.

On parents' night, there were the arts and crafts all laid out like appetizers. We took our seat in the church, and the children sang a song about the ark, Hallelujah, and one in which they had to jump up and down for Jesus. I can't remember ever feeling so uncertain about what's comic. What's serious. Evolution is magical, but devoid of heroes. You can't say to your child, Evolution loves you. The story stinks of extinction, and nothing exciting happens for centuries. I didn't have a wonderful story for my child. On the way home, in the car, she sang the

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songs. Occasionally standing up for Jesus. There was nothing to do but drive, ride it out, and sing along, in silence. But then, it occurred to us. You can't teach disbelief to a child. Only wonderful stories. And we didn't have a story nearly as good.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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